Wave and Rang De Korea have given the thriving I-Heart-Korea community more avenues to come together and celebrate. At the K Town festival in Mumbai last year, more than 7,000 people turned up, some dressing in the traditional attire *hanbok*, others learning Korean fan painting or singing karaoke in *noraebang*s, the popular Korean song rooms. Shital Sikarwar, a housewife-turned-entrepreneur and CEO & founder of TANI Events & Entertainment, which organises K Town, plans to go bigger this year. "Indians love to experience newness," she says. "Get into the depth of Korean culture, and there's a lot of resemblance. The way we respect elders, speak of family..." K Town has hosted concerts by Korean band Blackswan, whose members include Sriya Lenka, India's first K-Pop idol, along with stars like Chen and Xiumin of EXO and BamBam from Got7. HYBE, the label that represents bands like BTS, ENHYPEN and Seventeen, is set to start operations in Mumbai later this year, fuelling hope among Indian K-boppers about their favourite bands coming to perform in their cities.

Cross-cultural collaborations, too, are thriving. Sriya and Aria of X:IN (see interview, *'I can't imagine myself doing anything else'*) have proved that Indians can seamlessly fit into the K-Pop mould. Twenty-two-year-old Anushka Sen, an actress and influencer from Mumbai, was appointed tourism ambassador for 2023–24 and has made eight trips to South Korea since 2022. Comfortable now navigating the streets of Seoul, she has shot for two Korean projects: a web series called *Crush* and a film titled *Asia*, expected to release next year. She has even got herself a Korean name: Seon Yeo-myung. "Representing India on a global level is a great honour," she says.

WHY THE K WAVE, DI?

Thirty-four-year-old Nikita Engheepi, founder of the contributor-driven website Namaste Hallyu, and Pink Box Entertainment, recalls how in the '90s, she'd buy CDs and DVDs of Korean dramas back home in Nagaland for Rs 50-60 and trade photos of Korean actors and bands like Lee Min Ho, Lee Joon-gi, Bigbang, Super Junior with classmates. "Hindi was as foreign to us as Korean was," she says. "At least with Korean shows, we had English subtitles."

The rest of the country, meanwhile, was busy consuming homegrown *saas-bahu* dramas, American shows like *Friends*, or a Pakistani serial or two. Korean drama grabbed attention only during the Covid pandemic, with the rise of streaming platforms. In locked-down times, Korean romances offered a much-needed escape and their content felt deeply relatable. "Korean writers talk about themes that resonate beautifully with us," says Monika Shergill, VP, Netflix India. "They are about human relationships, human frailty, about love and jealousy. What women appreciate a lot are the love stories and having male characters who unconditionally love you."

Their high chastity quotient likely made K-dramas ideal for family viewing in India, compared to the violence, nudity and crude language often found in shows from the West. "My entire family loves *Extraordinary Attorney Woo*," says Sajal Jain, 28, cofounder of Delhi-based factory automation startup Bharatlytics. India and South Korea also share the fear and nostalgia for a severed sibling-nation. *Crash Landing on You*, a hugely popular K-Drama, tells the story of a South Korean heiress who falls for a North Korean army officer, exploring the familiar dilemma of cross-border romance to binge-worthy effect.

The latest FICCI-EY report on the

K-BEAUTY FOREVER YOUNG

The famous 10-step Korean beauty regimen is customisable and consumers can pick three to five ones daily, focusing on layering, hydration and protection. The steps include

- Oil Cleanser
- Foam/Water Cleanser
- Exfoliator (2–3 times/week)
- Toner
- Essence
- Serum / Ampoule
- Sheet Mask (2–3 times/week)
- Eye Cream
- Moisturiser
- SPF (AM) / Sleeping Pack (PM)



RAJWANT RAWAT